GEC1044 Chinese Medicine: Theory and Practice



Final Project (Individual)【30%】

Improving the physical and mental health of university students

A Pattern-Based Food Therapy Approach to Nourishment and Everyday Student Wellbeing

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1 Introduction

Experiencing restricted physical activity made me appreciate how limited energy can complicate everyday tasks. This motivated a recipe for university students that keeps equipment and active preparation manageable. A familiar one-pot congee offers a practical starting point for that aim.

This project addresses fatigue, loss of appetite, unsettled sleep and stress among university students through a Chinese yam, lotus seed and red date congee for home preparation. Irregular meals, academic pressure and limited cooking time make a simple, repeatable recipe relevant to this group. The analysis uses course concepts of pattern differentiation, food properties and ingredient combination to explain the design, while a brief psychological perspective considers its place in student routines.

My photograph of a pulse diagnosis slide at Thong Chai connects this concern with Lecture 7's emphasis on combining observations and history (Figure 1). A single symptom starts an inquiry; the whole presentation guides the response.

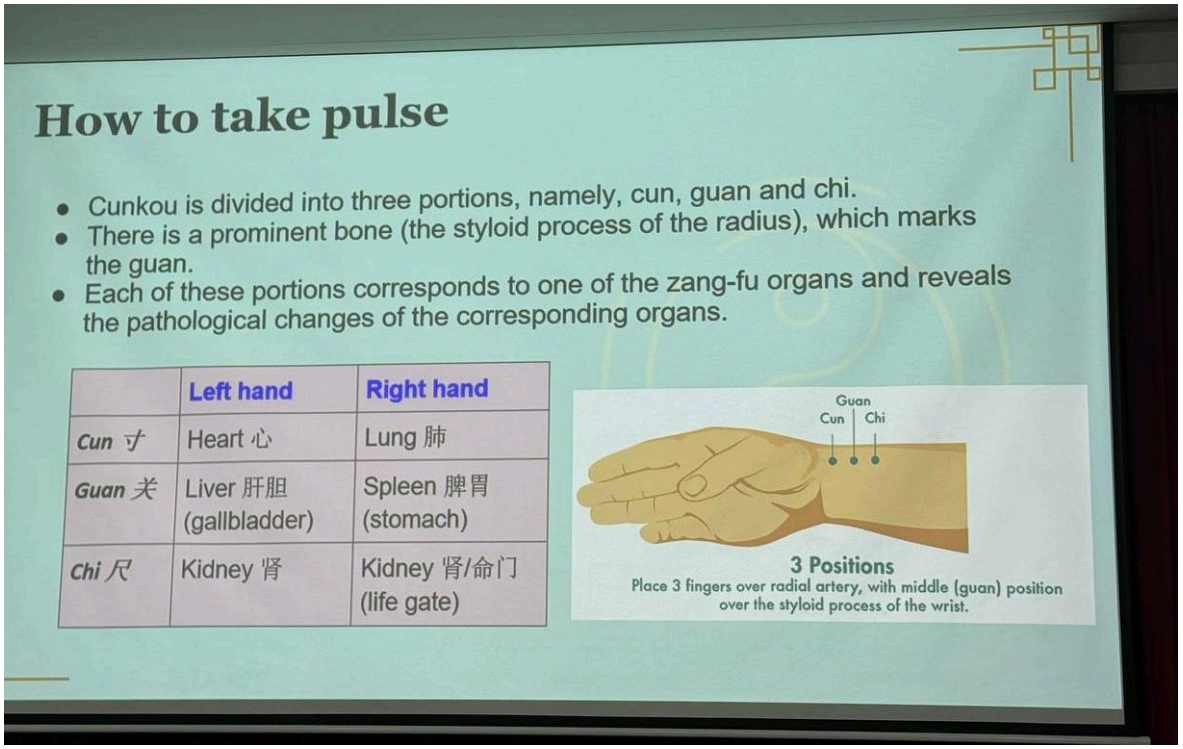


Figure 1 Pulse positions explained during the Thong Chai teaching session. Photograph by the author.

2 Understanding the health concerns

2.1 A Chinese medicine perspective

The recipe needs a more specific basis than the idea that tired students need nourishing food. Lecture 7 distinguishes a symptom from a pattern, or zheng（证型）: the same complaint can occur in different combinations of signs. The four diagnostic methods establish that combination before a treatment principle is chosen. Here I use possible patterns to explain the recipe's design, rather than diagnose my earlier movement difficulties.

Fatigue together with poor appetite suggests investigating Spleen qi deficiency（脾气虚）. Within Chinese medicine, the Spleen and Stomach receive and transform food; reduced

nourishment gives a traditional explanation for linking eating poorly with low energy. Inquiry would therefore cover meal regularity, stool consistency and whether tiredness persists after rest. The practitioner would also examine the tongue and pulse. Sleep disturbance alone would not establish this digestive pattern.

If poor appetite and fatigue accompany easily interrupted sleep, palpitations and a pale complexion, the question becomes whether Heart and Spleen deficiency（心脾两虚）gives a better account. A Chinese University of Hong Kong booklet describes this combination with loose stools and a pale tongue with a thin white coating. I use its description of the pattern, which appears in a booklet for young cancer survivors, without applying that population's treatment plan to students. The Heart's association with shen, or mental and emotional activity, explains why this line of reasoning includes sleep as well as digestion.

Academic stress also belongs in this pattern discussion. Lecture 10 distinguishes normal emotions from prolonged or excessive emotional activity within the Chinese medical framework, where Heart and Spleen name functional systems rather than simply anatomical organs. In the HKU School of Chinese Medicine account, excessive brooding can constrain qi and impair the Spleen's transformation of food, linking reduced appetite and bloating with diminished nourishment and energy (蔡頴輝, 2017). In a student scenario, sustained worry about deadlines could therefore prompt inquiry into both eating and sleep. Read alongside the Heart-Spleen pattern above, this offers a traditional rationale for considering digestion and mental rest together; it is not a biomedical explanation of stress.

This link supports the congee's chosen direction when worry accompanies signs of deficiency, but it does not make stress itself a diagnosis. The ingredients are selected for their traditional digestive and nourishing roles, rather than as a general treatment for academic pressure. Persistent emotional distress requires assessment beyond a household recipe.

The corresponding food therapy（食疗）principle is to support the Spleen and nourishment while including ingredients traditionally used to calm shen（神）. Yam and rice establish the digestive focus; lotus seeds connect that focus with calming shen; dates add a small nourishing component. This chain makes the ingredient choice answer the proposed pattern. The Department of Health also lists rice, yam and dates in dietary guidance for qi deficiency constitution, a broader category than a current clinical pattern.

Alternative signs change the direction. Hong Kong University's discussion links Liver fire insomnia with irritability and phlegm heat with gastric bloating, a heavy head and a bitter taste. Such a presentation needs a different assessment and principle, rather than simply more tonic ingredients. Lecture 9 makes the same point through a cooling heat-dampness soup described as unsuitable for a weak Spleen and Stomach. The present congee is therefore a focused nourishing option within the traditional framework, not a general insomnia remedy.

2.2 Individualized care: a parallel from acupuncture

Lecture 8's distinction between reinforcing deficiency and reducing excess illustrates why an intervention must follow assessment rather than a symptom label. My Thong Chai photograph records the acupuncture teaching context (Figure 2); the comparison with food therapy concerns this reasoning principle, not a claim that the two interventions have the same effects. For this congee, a possible Spleen qi or Heart-Spleen deficiency pattern explains the nourishing direction. Liver fire or phlegm heat presentations require a different assessment, so ingredients should not be added simply because a student reports insomnia.



Figure 2 Acupuncture teaching at Thong Chai. Photograph by the author; the slide records precautions, while the comparison of treatment principles draws on Lecture 8.

2.3 Psychology and recipe usability

Building on the discussion of si（思虑, sustained mental preoccupation）, a biopsychosocial perspective considers physical condition, psychological processes and social circumstances together (Hooley, Nock and Butcher, 2021). Applied to this project's student scenario, academic demands and rumination about unfinished work may coincide with disrupted sleep, poor appetite and fatigue; less energy for studying and preparing meals can then make daily routines harder to sustain. This is the project's interpretation of a possible reinforcing cycle, not a causal sequence established by the textbook for all students. It complements the traditional Heart-Spleen analysis by attending to the same concerns through daily habits and context; it neither equates rumination with depleted Spleen qi nor confirms a particular zheng.

The shared concern is how to make nourishment and everyday care manageable when energy is limited. Behavioural activation emphasizes achievable activities with tangible outcomes (Cacioppo, Freberg and Cacioppo, 2022). Here, one saucepan and few preparation steps reduce the effort of starting, familiar ingredients reduce shopping decisions, and two planned portions reduce repeated preparation. Completing a meal may offer a small sense of progress, but the long simmer still requires scheduling. This also fits yangsheng（养生, nourishing life）as care integrated into ordinary routines. Chinese medicine supplies the ingredient-selection rationale; psychology supports the recipe's accessibility, without demonstrating a psychological treatment effect.

3 The recipe and its ingredients

3.1 Chinese yam lotus seed and red date congee

I designed the congee around a simple aim: make a nourishing meal that is easy to prepare, with a traditional rationale linking digestion and mental rest. The starting point is the Hong Kong Department of Health's yam and red date congee. Its published example uses 200 g yam and 30 g red dates with rice. My version adds lotus seeds, uses 15 g red dates for a lighter sweetness, and specifies the rice and water so that the cooking process can be repeated.

The proposed batch makes two portions. All quantities below are planned kitchen weights. Fresh yam and dried ingredients are listed separately because their weights and preparation differ.

The 20 g lotus seeds give 10 g of dried seeds per intended portion. This makes them a supporting ingredient alongside 100 g fresh yam, rather than the main bulk of the meal. Their traditional digestive and calming functions explain their inclusion; the exact weight is a kitchen design choice for this first version. The 15 g dates give 7.5 g per portion, half the Department of Health example's batch quantity. This keeps dates subordinate to yam and reduces the amount of dried fruit while retaining some sweetness. These food weights do not establish a therapeutic dose or a measured effect on sleep.

Ingredient	Planned weight	Specification
Chinese yam	200 g	Fresh peeled edible portion
Lotus seeds	20 g	Dried shelled seeds with green embryos removed
Red dates	15 g	Dried pitted edible portion
Rice	80 g	Dry uncooked white rice
Water	1,000 ml	Starting amount; add if needed during cooking

3.2 From pattern to food therapy（理—法—方—食）

The reasoning proceeds from pattern explanation (li, 理), to a dietary principle (fa, 法), to a combination (fang, 方), and finally to foods and preparation (shi, 食). For the possible Spleen qi and Heart-Spleen deficiency patterns above, the principle is to strengthen the Spleen and replenish qi（健脾益气）, while nourishing the Heart and calming shen（养心安神）where sleep is unsettled. This is a specific nourishing direction within the broader yin–yang（阴阳）framework, not a claim that all student fatigue has the same cause.

Lecture 9's idea of medicine and food sharing a common origin（药食同源）explains why familiar ingredients can be considered through traditional food properties. It does not make a meal equivalent to a medicinal prescription. Yam establishes the digestive focus, lotus seeds connect it with calming shen, dates add supporting nourishment and sweetness, and rice provides the meal base. The following analysis tests each choice against that principle; the quantities remain planned food weights, not therapeutic doses.

3.3 Ingredient properties and roles

Chinese yam, shan yao（山药）, has the chief role in this design because it anchors the digestive aim. PolyU describes dried yam rhizome as sweet and neutral, with affinities to the Spleen, Lung and Kidney and a traditional role in supporting the Spleen and Stomach. The relevant connection here is its Spleen-supporting function, rather than every use listed in the monograph. This recipe uses 200 g fresh peeled yam, following the Department of Health's food preparation. Fresh yam and the dried reference material in Figure 3 are distinct preparations; their weights do not establish equivalent potency.

Lotus seed, lian zi（莲子）, supports yam while linking digestion with mental rest. PolyU lists sweet and astringent flavour, neutral nature, and Spleen, Kidney and Heart affinities; its

traditional functions include supporting the Spleen and calming shen（神, mental and emotional activity）. These functions explain its supporting role in the proposed Heart-Spleen direction. The 20 g dried seeds remain a kitchen design choice. Use shelled seeds and remove the green embryos, which are distinct from the seed material chosen for this meal.

Red dates, da zao（大枣／红枣）, provide a smaller nourishing and flavouring component. PolyU lists them as sweet and warm, associated with the Spleen and Stomach, with traditional functions of supplementing middle qi and nourishing blood and calming shen. The monograph's Spleen–Stomach attribution is retained here. Fifteen grams per batch gives 7.5 g per planned portion and limits dried-fruit sweetness without added sugar; this quantity has not been shown to guarantee a particular physiological effect.

White rice（大米）is the food base. Lecture 9 places rice among sweet foods associated with nourishment; the Department of Health also includes it in dietary guidance for qi deficiency constitution. Its observable cooking role is to thicken the congee and carry the other ingredients in a familiar soft meal. That supports everyday use without requiring a claim that rice acts as a medicinal envoy or cancels the properties of other ingredients.

Ingredient	Nature and flavour	Traditional affinity	Role in this congee
Chinese yam  PolyU reference	Neutral and sweet	Spleen Lung Kidney	Main digestive and nourishing focus
Lotus seed  PolyU reference	Neutral sweet and astringent	Spleen Kidney Heart	Links digestive support with calming shen
Red date  PolyU reference	Warm and sweet	Spleen Stomach	Supporting nourishment and natural sweetness
Rice	Sweet in the lecture classification	Food base	Provides a familiar meal and soft texture

Figure 3 Ingredient reference photographs from The Hong Kong Polytechnic University: dried yam rhizome, lotus seeds and red dates. These are reference specimens, not the author's cooking record; fresh yam is used in the recipe and green lotus embryos are removed.

My Thong Chai photograph shows the framework applied here (Figure 4): nature, flavour, meridian affinity and function are separate questions about each ingredient.

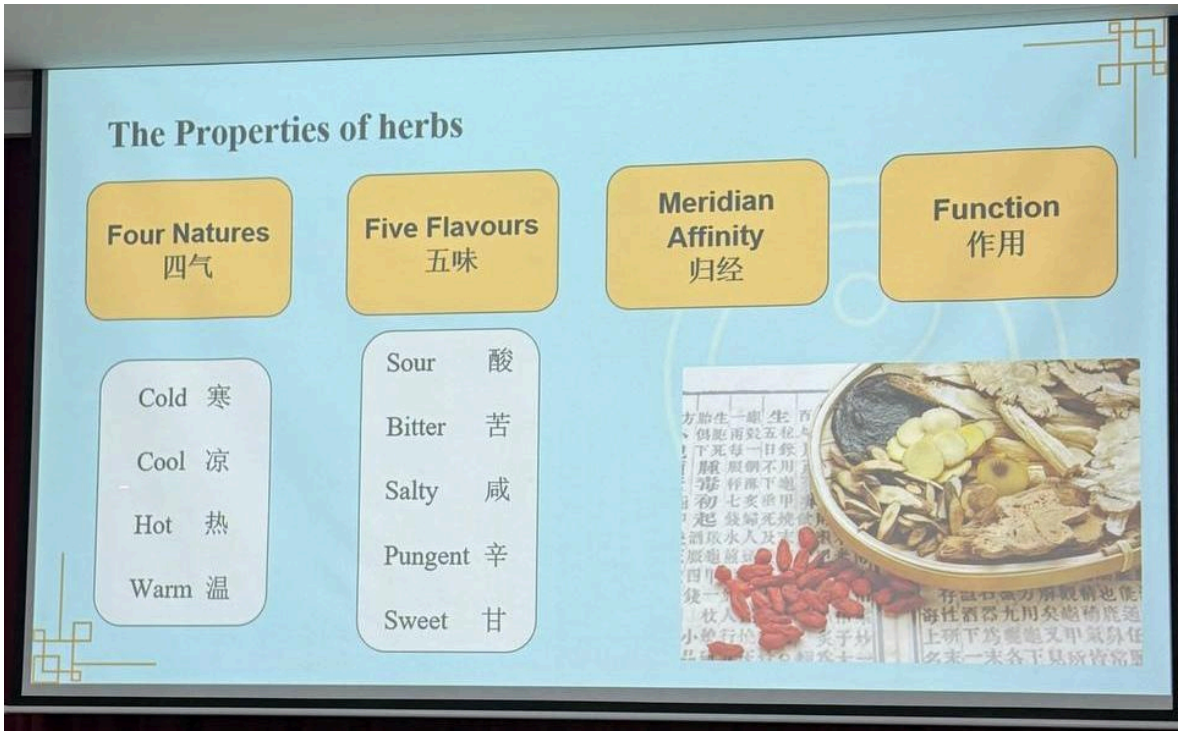


Figure 4 A teaching slide on the properties of herbs at Thong Chai. Photograph by the author.

3.4 Combination and design restraint

Lecture 9's jun–chen–zuo–shi（君臣佐使, chief–minister–assistant–envoy）framework helps distinguish a main aim from supporting functions. Yam has a chief-like role and lotus seed a minister-like role. Dates provide a supporting food component, but this design does not demonstrate that they counteract adverse effects in the strict assistant sense. Rice supplies the food base rather than being assigned an unverified channel-guiding action. The framework is used to explain priorities, not to force four foods into four medicinal roles; fresh and dried weights also cannot rank their medicinal strength.

This restraint follows the course's account of the Zhang Zhongjing tradition: the patient's presentation guides formula selection. Adding ginseng or further tonics would need a new rationale from the presentation, not merely a desire to make the meal stronger. Keeping the combination short limits shopping and preparation and makes the first cooking trial easier to evaluate. It does not establish that the foods act synergistically or that a more complex recipe would be harmful.

4 Home preparation and practical evaluation

4.1 Preparation method

For this recipe, use a saucepan with a lid, a kitchen scale and a measuring jug. Weigh the edible portions listed above. Rinse the lotus seeds and follow the packet's soaking instructions, checking that the green embryos have been removed. Wash the rice. Peel the yam with gloves if its sap irritates the skin, then cut it into small pieces. Wash and pit the dates.

Place the rice, lotus seeds and 1,000 ml water in the saucepan. Bring to the boil, then reduce the heat to a gentle simmer. Add the yam and dates and cook until the rice breaks down and the lotus seeds are tender. Stir occasionally and add water if needed. Allow about 45 to 60

minutes of cooking, in addition to ingredient preparation and any soaking. Tenderness is the final check. Divide into two portions and serve warm.

A one-pot method reduces equipment and washing up, but an hour of cooking still requires planning. This is more realistic for a planned evening or weekend meal than for a rushed morning. Preparing two portions together can spread that work across two meals, or allow two people to share the batch. If saving a portion, cool it quickly, ideally within one hour, refrigerate, and use within 24 hours; reheat only once until steaming hot throughout, following Food Standards Agency advice for cooked rice.

4.2 Serving and everyday use

Serve one planned portion warm as part of a regular meal, choosing a time when soaking and simmering are manageable. For a first trial, use one freshly cooked batch and evaluate taste, tolerance, timing and yield before deciding whether to repeat it. No evidence-based weekly frequency has been established for this specific congee. Lecture 10's yangsheng（养生） framework places food alongside rest, movement and emotional cultivation: a regular mealtime and sleep schedule, with manageable activity such as a gentle campus walk, provide a practical setting for dietary care. Water temperature can follow comfort and preference. Simple preparation and flexible scheduling link this food therapy design with the behavioural considerations above.

4.3 Intended users and suitability

The design addresses fatigue and poor appetite where assessment suggests Spleen qi deficiency（脾气虚）, or Heart-Spleen deficiency（心脾两虚）when sleep is also unsettled. It is a nourishing food option, not a general remedy for insomnia or stress. The Liver fire and phlegm-heat presentations discussed in Section 2 point toward different principles, such as clearing heat or resolving phlegm; this combination was not designed to fulfil those aims. Do not infer a suitable pattern from a symptom checklist alone. Use food-grade ingredients and account for allergies, prescribed diets and individual tolerance. Persistent fatigue, appetite loss, sleep problems, palpitations or emotional distress require appropriate professional assessment.

4.4 Cooking record (pending trial)

The congee has not yet been prepared, so this draft cannot report observed results. The required practical component remains incomplete. Complete the following record from an actual cooking trial before submission; the cover photograph and Thong Chai teaching photographs do not document this recipe's preparation.

Trial date: [to complete].

Actual edible weights: yam [ ] g; dried lotus seeds [ ] g; pitted dates [ ] g; dry rice [ ] g.

Water: starting [ ] ml; additional [ ] ml.

Timing: lotus seed soaking [ ]; active preparation [ ] minutes; simmering [ ] minutes.

Yield: [ ] g or ml; portions obtained [ ].

Cost: total ingredients S$[ ]; per portion S$[ ].

Record whether the yam and lotus seeds are tender, whether the rice has broken down, and whether the thickness and sweetness are acceptable. Note any sticking, extra water or longer cooking needed. Explain one change for a second trial using these observations. Taste and

cooking convenience can be evaluated here; a single meal cannot establish an improvement in a clinical condition.

4.5 Preparation photographs (pending trial)

[Insert own process photograph A: ingredients on the scale. Caption: date, ingredient identities and actual edible weights.]

[Insert own process photograph B: prepared ingredients before cooking. Caption: soaked lotus seeds with green embryos removed, peeled yam and pitted dates.]

[Insert own process photograph C: congee during simmering. Caption: elapsed time and any additional water or adjustments.]

[Insert own process photograph D: finished congee divided into portions. Caption: final cooking time, actual yield and observed texture.]

5 Reflection and conclusion

The strength of this recipe is the sequence from zheng（证型）to a food therapy principle, ingredient roles and practical use. The possible Spleen qi deficiency direction explains the yam-and-rice base; the Heart-Spleen question explains why lotus seeds and a small amount of dates belong in the combination. Psychology adds an account of worry, disrupted routines and the effort of meal preparation. It helps make the design usable, while the traditional properties supply the ingredient rationale. Comparing this direction with heat-related sleep disturbance defines the recipe's limits.

The main practical limitation is time: one saucepan reduces equipment, but soaking and simmering still require planning. Preparing two portions may make the work more manageable. The cooking trial must test whether the proposed weights, water and timing produce tender ingredients, acceptable sweetness and a usable portion at a reasonable cost. Until that trial and its photographs are added, practical feasibility remains a design claim rather than a demonstrated result.

This project therefore addresses the physical and mental health of university students through a focused food therapy design. Its intended contribution is a manageable meal supported by course-based reasoning, not evidence of a treatment for fatigue, insomnia or stress. The next step is to prepare the congee, document the process and revise the recipe in light of the actual result.

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